

AN ICON

headlines and his movies were alternately applauded and attacked. So sometimes he was Greta Garbo (I'm a loner, I have no friends), at other times he was Howard Roark (I don't believe in God). His past was never something he liked to talk about, and the family that he visits even now in Hyderabad has been firmly kept out of public view—after all, it doesn't sit too well with his opposition to *karva chauth* cinema. As he says even now, "I have no social life, no family life. All I know is how to make movies."

It's not that he hasn't worked hard. He lives and breathes cinema. "Everything is a studio for him, his home, his car and the sets," says writer Jaideep Sahni. Nagarjuna, who starred in Varma's debut film in Telugu, *Shiva*, in 1989—he rejected his first idea, of a horror film—was blown away with his technical expertise. "Till then, I just knew him as part of the same clique of friends and cousins. I had never seen such a visual

quality in anyone's narration before," says the actor, who worked with him in two subsequent Telugu-Hindi films but chose to stay on in Hyderabad despite Varma's coaxing that Mumbai was the future. Varma has since directed 26 films, and produced 13 more (many of them directed by former assistants, and in one case of supreme arrogance, even the man who designed his office). Along the way, he has also spun off great talent—from *Page 3* director Madhur Bhandarkar who assisted him for five years to *Chak De! India* director Shimit Amin who edited *Bhoot* for him in 2003, from Manoj Bajpai whom he spotted in a small role in *Daud* to Rajpal Yadav whom he cast first in *Mast*. And yet, not only has he been unable to respect good minds but also he has not created credible second line of command, so essential when a filmmaker decides to raise the scale of production. "He is full of ideas," says his former associate, writer-turned-director

RAM GOPAL VARMA'S GIRLS

The director likes to repeat his heroines. Not all are talented.

URMILA MATONDKAR

"The first five films she did with me flopped. Then *Rangeela* worked. Does that mean she didn't have the potential earlier?" asks Varma. Her last full-fledged role in his films was in *Ek Hasina Thi*. She reappeared in the *Mehbooba* song in *Aag*. The effect? Pfft.

NISHA KOTHARI

"My belief in her won't change. If anyone is to blame for promoting her, it should be me. I think she has suited the character wherever I have cast her," says Varma. As we choke on that, chew on this. Seven films for Varma, without a hit, three for others since she came to Mumbai from Kolkata in 2003.

ANTARA MALI

In her nine-film career, she has done only one that is not produced or directed by Varma. The actor even wrote, co-directed and acted in a film he produced, proving to be a nightmare for her co-workers with her diva demands. Now on the lookout for a publicist and work.

